

YOUN BAEK

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EDUCATION

NYU Stern School of Business Ph.D. in Economics	<i>2019 - 2025 (Expected)</i>
Korea University M.A. in Economics	<i>2018</i>
Korea University B.B.A. in Business Administration	<i>2016</i>
Arizona State University Semester abroad	<i>2016</i>

INTERESTS

innovation, political economy

RESEARCH

Working papers

Missionaries and the Birth of International Development [Draft]

The United States is the world's leading provider of foreign aid. Is this driven by humanitarian motives or strategic interests? I examine how Protestant missionaries helped shape American support for international development. Using the travel routes of Student Volunteer Movement recruiters as an instrument, I find that greater exposure to missionaries through church denominations increased congressional support for major foreign aid bills that established modern development assistance. Missionary influence led church denominations to advocate for aid in congressional testimony and encouraged policymakers to frame it in terms of human dignity rather than strategic concerns. Beyond advocacy in Congress, missionaries became key experts on non-European societies, producing social science research and advising the U.S. government during early development initiatives. In the long run, missionary influence contributed to a sustained commitment to global development, reflected in increased Peace Corps participation.

Estimating the supply elasticity of innovation [Draft]

Government R&D may pass through to higher scientists' wages rather than an increase in innovation when the labor supply of scientific workforce is inelastic. This paper leverages granular data on scientists' productivity, wages, and research funding to estimate the impact of government R&D on both inventive output and wages. To identify these effects, I exploit variation in city size driven by universities' historical ties to defense funding, which influenced the geographic distribution of scientists through the placement of graduates into research-intensive cities. I find that government R&D funding increases inventive output, particularly among scientists who do not receive funding themselves. The monetary value of increased inventions outweighs the increase in labor costs. While R&D subsidies do lead to higher wages, the results suggest that government investment in research can significantly boost

overall innovation output by attracting new scientists and generating knowledge spillovers. However, a back-of-the-envelope calculation from a simple model indicates that a decline in labor supply elasticity could dampen the productivity gains from government research.

Path dependence through agglomeration spillovers: Evidence from the beet sugar industry (submitted) [Draft]

This paper investigates the agglomeration spillovers from beet sugar factories, which brought manufacturing jobs near farmlands and were supported by the U.S. government as an industrial policy at the turn of the twentieth century. To estimate the effects of plant openings, I identify runner-up locations for beet sugar plants from a historical trade journal and find that these plant openings had large and long-lasting effects on population and manufacturing activities over one hundred years. The local jobs multiplier was significantly larger in less populated areas, suggesting that low congestion during the early period of frontier settlement enabled a substantial impact. The agglomeration spillovers benefited industries not only directly linked through input-output linkages but also extended to broader, less related industries outside the production chain of agricultural processing.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Undergraduate:	Microeconomics with Algebra, Microeconomics with Calculus (Spring 2021, Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Fall 2022, Spring 2023, Fall 2023, Spring 2024) Teaching assistant: Prof. Guillaume Haeringer, Prof. Gianluca Clementi, Prof. Simon Bowmaker, Prof. Tommaso Denti, Prof. Jacob French
MBA:	Firms and Markets (Fall 2021, Spring 2022) Teaching assistant: Prof. Maher Said, Prof. Simon Bowmaker Economics of Creativity and Innovation (Fall 2021) Teaching assistant: Prof. Petra Moser

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

2023	Kurnow PhD Fellowship, New York University
2019	Doctoral Fellowship, Ilju Academic Foundation
2019	Doctoral Fellowship, Kwanjeong Educational Foundation (declined)
2019	Doctoral Fellowship, NYU Stern
2016	Undergraduate Thesis Grant, Korea University
2015	Undergraduate Fellowship, Korea Foundation for Advanced Studies

PRESENTATIONS

2025: Northwestern Kellogg Political Economy Rookiefest*; Wharton AI and the Future of Work conference (poster)*; Annual Meeting of the Academy of Management (poster)*; Society for Institutional Organizational Economics (UNSW)*; Laboratory for the Economics of Africa's Past (Stellenbosch)*; Pacific Conference for Development Economics (PacDev); Association for the Study of Religion, Economics, and Culture Conference (ASREC) **2023:** North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association **2021:** Yale Economic History Graduate Student Conference

**Scheduled*

OTHER

Programming skills: Stata (advanced), Python (intermediate), R (intermediate), QGIS

Languages: English (fluent), Korean (native)

Citizenship: South Korea (F1 visa)

REFERENCES

Petra Moser (Chair)

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